Ochterlonys had been forced to flee to Canada; from thence, via Britain, David had entered the Company's army in 1777. Ochterlony also knew better than most of his contemporaries the etiquette concerning the protection of Muslim women: according to Delhi gossip, he had no fewer than thirteen Indian wives and every evening during his years in Delhi was said to have taken all thirteen on a promenade between the walls of the Red Fort and the river bank, each wife on her own elephant.[20]

Now, with characteristic gallantry, he took up the cause of Wa'fa Begum, accusing Metcalfe of heartlessness in abandoning the fallen Queen: the Begum, he wrote, 'was in a forlorn and helpless state . . . A foreigner, a stranger, and a woman of high birth is in misery, and has thrown herself on the protection of a government famed for its humanity and generosity. As the agent of that government I am most anxious to do every justice to its high character.' He then added, presciently, 'England has long afforded an asylum and support to exiled princes, and the most unexpected revolutions have restored them to their thrones under circumstances much more improbable than the restoration of Shah Shuja. In which case, though the gratitude of princes is not proverbial, the hospitality of the British government might give us a friend in a quarter where one may someday be required.'[21] Ochterlony's argument persuaded the Governor General, and the Begum was given asylum.

Wa'fa Begum and her women had limped into Ludhiana from Lahore on 2 December 1814. The one British official in the town that day reported their bedraggled arrival, and their nervousness about crossing the British frontier without passports or permissions. 'I thought it would allay their apprehensions to send them word that they might rest assured of their personal security,' he wrote. 'I was sorry that I had no better accommodation to offer them than the tent I had prepared for them. They expressed their gratitude for the kind reception, but begged to decline troubling me for anything – saying that the protection of the British government was all they would ever ask or receive from us.'[22]

Within a few months, however, once news of her reception had spread, the number of the Begum's dependants had increased to ninety-six, and she moved to a semi-ruinous haveli that Ochterlony found for her. As she had no means of support, Ochterlony initially paid the Begum's bills from his own pocket. Later, he managed to secure her a small annuity from the government.